

# **Childcare as Workforce Infrastructure:**

## **The Two-Child Cost Burden**

Dan Morrow

DSC640: Data Presentation and Visualization

Bellevue University

August 2026

## Summary of Analysis

This project uses the National Database of Childcare Prices to show how childcare becomes a workforce issue when a family has more than one young child in care. The dataset is organized at the county-year level and includes childcare prices, geography, year, household income, population characteristics, and labor force-related measures. For this story, I focused on center-based infant care and center-based preschool care because that combination creates a realistic two-child scenario for many families.

The story is built around a simple idea: one childcare slot is already expensive, but two young children in care can change the entire household budget. When the combined cost of infant and preschool care is compared with county median household income, the issue becomes larger than a private family expense. It connects directly to workforce stability because families may have to decide whether both parents can keep working, whether one parent should reduce hours, or whether a job still makes financial sense after childcare is paid.

The main message is that childcare should be treated as workforce infrastructure. In this project, workforce infrastructure means the supports that make steady employment possible. Transportation helps people get to work, job training helps people qualify for work, and affordable childcare helps parents stay attached to work. Without that support, families, employers, and local economies can all feel the pressure.

## Findings

The strongest finding is that two-child childcare costs create a much larger burden than looking at one child alone. In 2018, the median annualized cost of center-based infant care was \$7,987, and the median annualized cost of center-based preschool care was \$6,500. When those

two categories are combined, the median two-child cost was \$14,850. That equals about 29.7% of county median household income.

The trend also moves upward over time. The median two-child cost increased from \$11,828 in 2008 to \$14,850 in 2018. That is a 25.5% increase across the period. This matters because the story isn't only that childcare is expensive in one year. The data also shows that the two-child cost burden has grown over time.

The burden also isn't evenly distributed across the country. Some states and counties show much higher affordability pressure than others. In the dashboard draft, 1,138 counties were at or above a 30% two-child childcare burden in 2018, and 195 counties were at or above 40%. This makes the story more actionable because it points to where support may be needed most. County examples help make the burden easier to understand. Bronx County, New York showed a two-child burden of 93.0% in the 2018 dashboard view, while Milwaukee County, Wisconsin showed a burden of 63.2%. These examples aren't meant to say every family in those counties has the same experience. They show how comparing childcare cost to local income can reveal places where the pressure is especially high.

## Assumptions and Limitations

Several assumptions are built into this analysis. Weekly childcare prices were annualized by multiplying by 52 weeks. This makes the cost easier to understand and compare, but it doesn't reflect every family's real childcare schedule. Some families use part-time care, relatives, informal care, or different childcare arrangements during the year.

I also used county median household income as the comparison point. That is useful for comparing places, but it can't capture the full range of family income within a county. A family

earning below the county median may feel a much heavier burden, while a family earning above the median may feel less pressure. The two-child scenario also focuses on one infant and one preschool-aged child, which is realistic for many families but doesn't describe every household.

Another limitation is that childcare price data doesn't prove that childcare cost alone causes workforce decisions. Families make work decisions for many reasons, including wages, schedules, job flexibility, transportation, care availability, family support, and personal preference. This project uses the cost burden as a signal of pressure, not as proof of every individual family's decision.

## **Direction of Story and Main Message**

The final story direction is to show that childcare affordability is connected to workforce stability. The project focuses on families with two young children because that scenario creates a larger and more concrete burden than looking at one child alone. When childcare costs take up a large share of household income, the issue moves beyond one family's budget. It can affect whether parents can stay employed, work full-time, accept better jobs, or remain attached to the workforce.

The call to action is for policymakers, workforce leaders, employers, and community organizations to treat childcare affordability as an economic development issue. The goal isn't just to say childcare is expensive. The goal is to show where the pressure is highest and why that pressure matters for families and the workforce.

## Target Audience

The target audience includes state and local policymakers, workforce development leaders, employers, and community organizations focused on family economic stability. This audience probably already understands that childcare is expensive, but the two-child angle makes the issue more concrete. A single large number may get attention, but the burden measure helps explain why the same price can feel different depending on income and location.

The writing and visuals use plain language because the goal is to make the issue easy to understand. The audience shouldn't need advanced data training to follow the argument. The project uses direct labels, large takeaway numbers, simple comparisons, and clear callouts so the audience can quickly understand the size of the burden and why it matters.

## Mediums Included and Why

This final project includes three mediums because each one serves a different communication purpose.

| Medium                             | Purpose                                                                                           | Recommended final use                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PowerPoint presentation            | Stakeholder briefing for policymakers, workforce leaders, employers, and community organizations. | Use as the main guided presentation because it walks through the problem, evidence, location differences, workforce connection, and call to action. |
| One-page infographic               | Public-facing version for people who need the main takeaway quickly.                              | Use as a handout or supplement. It highlights the two-child pressure point and connects the cost burden to work impacts.                            |
| Dashboard or notebook-style medium | Exploratory version for stakeholders who want to compare places more directly.                    | Use as an exploratory dashboard-style medium with filters, KPI cards, county rankings, and local drilldowns.                                        |

## Design Decisions

The design decisions focus on keeping the message clear, organized, and visually consistent without adding unnecessary clutter. Across the mediums, navy is used for the main argument and structure, light blue is used for context, and amber, coral, or red tones are used for cost pressure and high-burden warning points.

The PowerPoint uses a stakeholder briefing format because that audience needs a guided argument, not an exploratory data dump. It moves from the two-child cost problem, to cost compared with income, to location differences, to the workforce connection, and then to the call to action. The infographic uses fewer charts and larger number callouts because it is designed for quick public communication. The dashboard or notebook medium uses filters, KPI cards, ranked tables, and local drilldowns because it is designed for exploration.

Gestalt principles are used through grouping, alignment, size, and spacing. Related information is placed close together, and the largest numbers are reserved for the most important findings. The overall goal is to make the mediums feel connected without making them repetitive.

## Ethical Considerations

The data comes from the National Database of Childcare Prices, a public source from the U.S. Department of Labor Women's Bureau. The data is aggregated at the county level and doesn't identify individual families, so privacy risk is low. Still, there are ethical issues in how the data is presented.

The biggest risk is overstating what the visuals prove. The visuals could make it seem like every family pays the same annualized cost or that childcare cost alone causes a parent to reduce hours or leave work. To reduce that risk, the project labels assumptions clearly, explains that weekly costs were annualized, and avoids presenting the burden measure as proof of every family's experience.

There is also a risk of making the problem look too simple. Childcare affordability is connected to income, geography, job flexibility, care availability, family structure, and policy choices. The project should be used as decision support, not as a complete explanation of every workforce decision. The ethical approach is to show the burden clearly while being honest about what the data can and can't prove.

## Lessons Learned

A fun takeaway was that the same dataset can support different stories depending on the audience and medium. A PowerPoint needs a guided argument, an infographic needs a fast takeaway, and a dashboard needs exploration while still staying true to the story. I also learned that burden is more meaningful than price alone because the same childcare cost can feel very different depending on local income.

If I were doing this again, I would plan the exact role of each medium earlier so the visuals are more distinct from the beginning. I would also decide earlier which outside information is supporting context and which information belongs in the main analysis. For this project, the National Database of Childcare Prices remains the main source because it directly supports the two-child cost burden story. The ReadyNation workforce information adds helpful context, but the childcare price data carries the main analysis.

Overall, the project shows that childcare affordability should be part of workforce and economic development conversations. The two-child cost burden is useful because it connects data to decisions that families, employers, policymakers, and communities face in the real world.

## References

ReadyNation. (2026). The child care crisis costs the U.S. economy \$172 billion each year.

Institute for Child Success.

<https://www.instituteforchildsuccess.org/resources/resource/cost-child-care-fact-sheet/>

U.S. Department of Labor, Women's Bureau. (2024). National Database of Childcare Prices.

<https://www.dol.gov/agencies/wb/topics/featured-childcare>

FINAL MEDIUM 1

# Stakeholder PowerPoint

A guided presentation for decision-makers who need the argument, evidence, and recommendation.

### Audience

Policymakers, employers, workforce leaders, and community organizations

### Purpose

Explain the two-child burden as a workforce issue

### Format

PowerPoint briefing

---

**Each medium uses the same data story but adapts the level of detail for a different audience.**

### The business case for treating childcare as infrastructure

**\$14,850**

Median 2018 annualized infant  
+ preschool care

**29.7%**

Median share of county  
household income

**+25.5%**

Increase in median two-child  
cost, 2008–2018

#### Recommendation

Treat childcare affordability as  
workforce infrastructure.

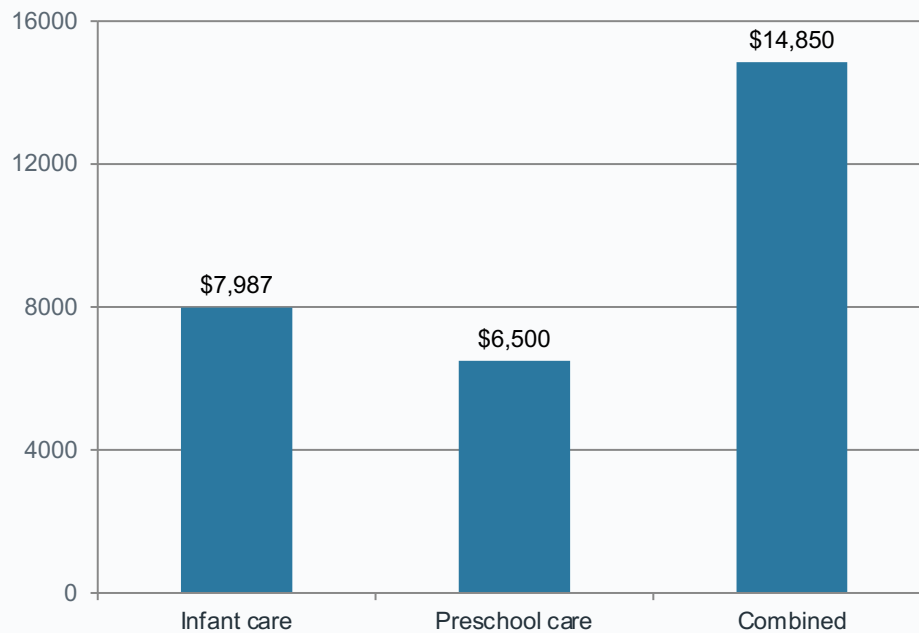
Use affordability burden data to  
target support where families,  
employers, and communities face  
the greatest pressure.

**Why it matters: When childcare consumes a large share of household income, it can become a barrier to staying in the workforce.**

## Two-child care becomes a household-level burden

STAKEHOLDER POWERPOINT

2018 median annualized center-based childcare prices.



### What the numbers show

The issue is not just the price of one childcare slot. It is the combined hit when families have more than one young child in care.

### Why it matters

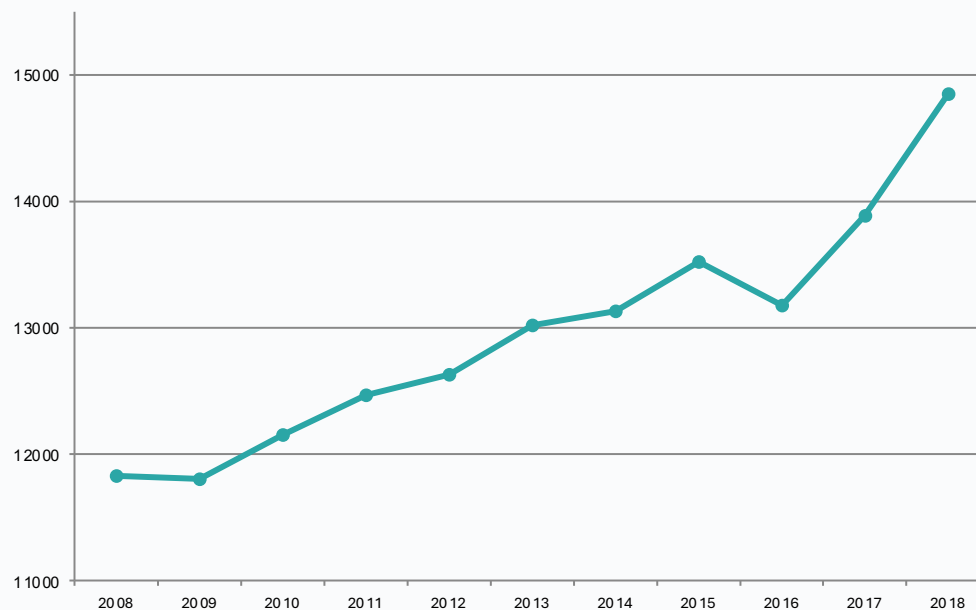
The childcare bill doesn't just add up. It can compete with housing, savings, and whether a parent can afford to keep working.

*Note: the combined value is a county-level median combined measure, so it doesn't have to equal the sum of the separate national medians.*

## The two-child cost moved steadily upward

STAKEHOLDER POWERPOINT

National median annualized combined infant + preschool care, 2008–2018.



### 2008

\$11,828  
Median annualized  
two-child cost.

### 2018

\$14,850  
Median annualized  
two-child cost.

**+25.5%**

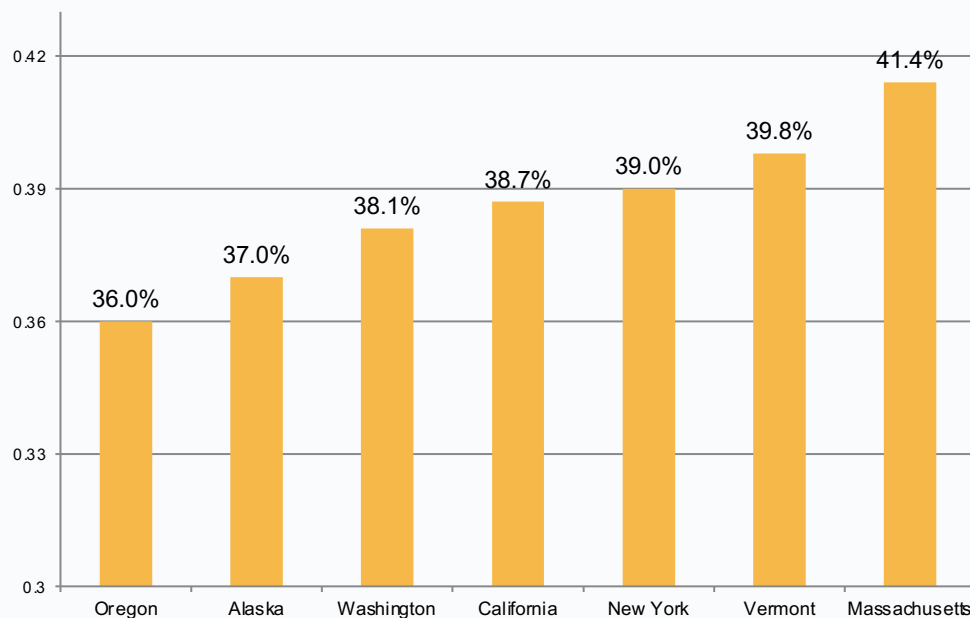
increase from 2008 to 2018

**Despite some year-to-year variation, the median two-child cost rose from \$11,828 in 2008 to \$14,850 in 2018. If that long-term pattern continues, childcare costs could keep rising.**

## The affordability burden is not evenly distributed

STAKEHOLDER POWERPOINT

Top states by median county two-child childcare burden in 2018.



### What the numbers show

Several states have a median county burden above one-third of household income. The pressure is place-based, not evenly shared across the country.

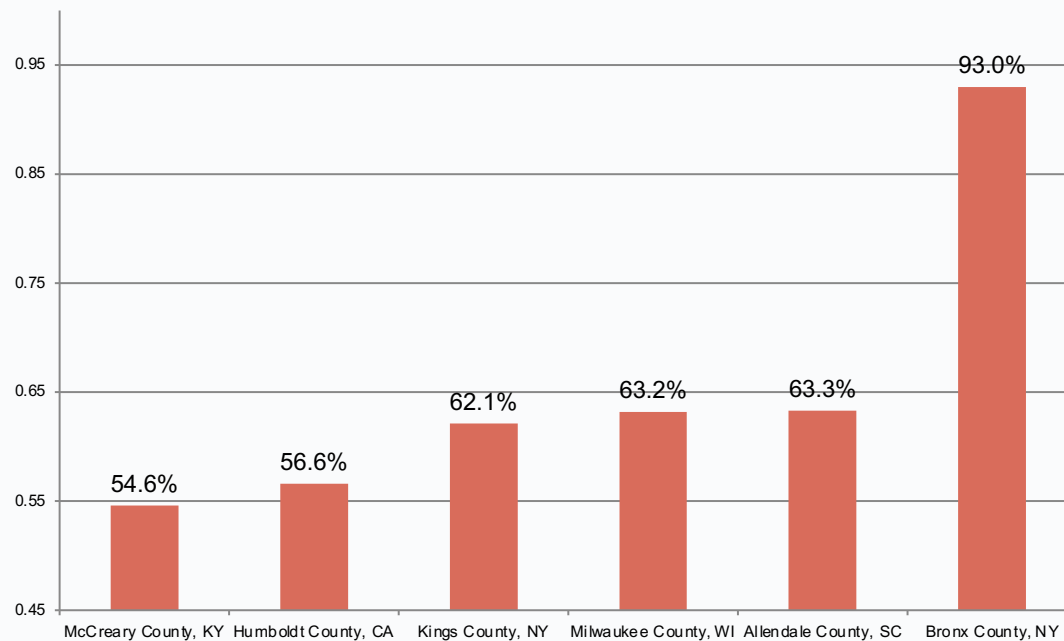
### Why it matters

Families in high-burden areas give up a larger share of household income to childcare. Focusing support there targets the places where affordability pressure is greatest and where workforce participation may be hardest to maintain.

## The burden is even sharper in some counties

STAKEHOLDER POWERPOINT

2018 examples ranked by two-child burden as a share of county median household income.



### Why burden matters

A high burden can come from high childcare prices, lower local income, or both. That means the same childcare cost can create very different levels of financial pressure depending on where a family lives.

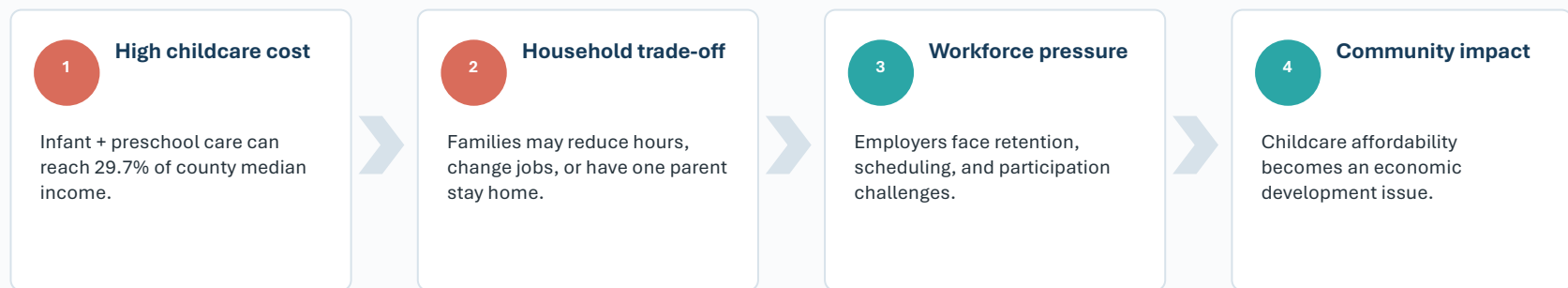
### Actionable measure

Burden helps identify where families are likely to feel the greatest pressure. Counties with the highest burden can be prioritized for childcare support, workforce programs, or other affordability efforts.

## Why this becomes a workforce issue

STAKEHOLDER POWERPOINT

The visual story connects family costs to employer and community outcomes.



### Business Takeaway

The data doesn't prove every individual family decision, but it shows the cost pressure is large enough to matter for work and household stability.

## Call to action: make childcare workforce strategy

STAKEHOLDER POWERPOINT

The data points to a practical next step: prioritize support where the burden is highest.

### Target high-burden areas

Use county and state burden measures to identify where affordability pressure is greatest.

### Support working families

Expand practical supports that help parents stay attached to the workforce.

### Bring employers into the solution

Treat childcare access as a retention and economic development issue, not only a private household issue.

### Call to Action

Affordable childcare helps working families, strengthens employers, and supports stronger local economies.

FINAL MEDIUM 2

### One-page infographic

A public-facing handout with large numbers and workforce impact statistics.

#### Audience

General public, advocates, employers, and community organizations

#### Purpose

Make the workforce consequence easy to see quickly

#### Format

Portrait-style infographic slide

---

**Each medium uses the same data story but adapts the level of detail for a different audience.**

### Childcare cost isn't just a family cost.

When care gets too expensive or hard to find, parents lose work hours or leave jobs entirely.

#### The two-child pressure point

National county medians for center-based infant + preschool care show how quickly the bill grows when a family has two young children in care at the same time.

**\$14,850**

annual median two-child  
care cost

**29.7%**

of county median  
household income

#### But the real story is the workforce hit.

ReadyNation's national survey of working parents with children under age 5 shows that childcare problems don't just create stress. They change work behavior.

**26%**

reported quitting a job because of  
childcare problems

#### Other work impacts reported by parents:



High childcare  
costs  
make work  
harder to keep

Parents reduce  
hours  
or leave jobs

Businesses lose  
labor,  
experience, and  
stability

**Call to action: Treat childcare affordability like workforce infrastructure, not just a private family expense.**

FINAL MEDIUM 3

### Dashboard / notebook medium

An exploratory version for stakeholders who need to ask, “what about my county?”

#### Audience

Analysts, policy staff, workforce planners, and local decision-makers

#### Purpose

Allow users to explore counties, states, years, and burden levels

#### Format

Dashboard mockups

---

**Each medium uses the same data story but adapts the level of detail for a different audience.**

## Dashboard page: national two-child burden explorer

DASHBOARD / NOTEBOOK

Interactive view with filters, KPIs, rankings, and state comparison.

YEAR  
2018

STATE  
All states

COUNTY  
All counties

CARE TYPE  
Center-based

CHILDREN  
Infant + Preschool

**2,360**

2018 counties with usable cost  
and income data

**\$7,987**

median infant care

**\$6,500**

median preschool care

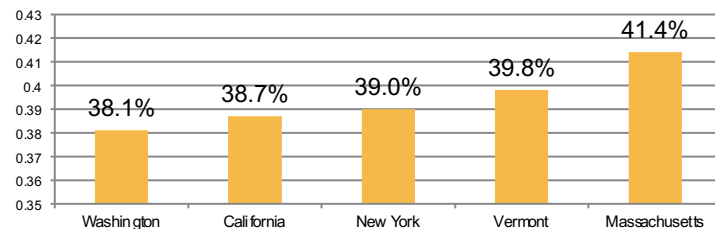
**\$14,850**

median two-child cost

**29.7%**

median income burden

### Highest state median burdens



### How to use this dashboard

1. Select year, state, county, and care scenario.
2. Compare cost and burden KPIs.
3. Review state or county rankings.
4. Use the result to support targeted childcare affordability decisions.

## Dashboard page: Local drilldown example

DASHBOARD / NOTEBOOK

Milwaukee County, Wisconsin, 2018.

**\$16,224**

annual infant care

**\$14,560**

annual preschool care

**\$30,784**

combined two-child cost

**\$48,742**

county median household  
income

**63.2%**

two-child burden

### Local interpretation

This drilldown demonstrates how the dashboard medium moves from a national summary to a local decision-making example. Milwaukee County's two-child burden is more than double the national county median burden.

### Planning question

Where are the households, employers, and workforce systems most exposed to the combined cost of infant + preschool care?

### National Database of Childcare Prices

U.S. Department of Labor, Women's Bureau. Project calculations use 2008–2018 data, center-based infant care, center-based preschool care, county median household income, and annualized weekly childcare prices.

### ReadyNation

The Child Care Crisis Costs the U.S. Economy \$172 Billion Each Year. Used in the public infographic to connect childcare problems to work-hour reduction, job changes, and parents leaving jobs.